"IF THERE'S ONE GOVERNMENT DETERMINED TO RESOLVE ALL OUTSTANDING ISSUES, IT'S THE AAP GOVERNMENT," SAYS A SOURCE FROM THE PARTY

affairs, particularly the powerful Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC), which is responsible for the management of gurdwaras in the states of Punjab, Himachal and Chandigarh. In the 2022 assembly election, the SAD vote share fell from 28 per cent to 18 per cent and its seat tally came down from 15 out of 117 seats in 2017 to a mere three in 2022. The Congress, too, after the departure of its stalwart and former chief minister Captain Amarinder Singh along with a host of other Congress MLAs before the elections, saw its vote share dip from 38 per cent to 23 per cent and seats from 77 to just 18. Votes from this kitty went to AAP, which saw its vote share catapult from 23 per cent to 42 per cent and seats from 20 to a phenomenal 92. Yet, AAP's influence over panthic issues remains limited, leaving a vacuum that the likes of Amritpal Singh and other newbies are freely exploiting. That the ruling party is willing to appease them rather than confront them, as in the Ajnala incident, is another reason, critics allege, for their growing popularity. The AAP source, though, denies the allegation. "Who brought the perpetrators of the Kotkapura-Behbal Kalan cases to book after so many years?" he asks. "If there is one government that is determined to resolve all outstanding issues and ensure justice is done, it is the Aam Aadmi Party government."

THE GANGS OF PUNJAB

In addition to Sikh radicals, there are several gangsters who are also aligning with erstwhile terrorists hiding in Pakistan, Europe and North American countries to smuggle drugs and weapons from Pakistan and also organise targeted killings. The mid-November killing of the Sirsa-based Dera Sacha Sauda follower Pradeep Singh at Kotkapura was suspected to have been executed by the henchmen of Canada-based gangster Satwinderjit Singh alias Goldy Brar. He is the same gangster who had claimed responsibility for orchestrating the murder of singer-turned-neta Sidhu Moosewala last May. In December, Mann claimed that Brar had been arrested in the US and would be extradited to India soon. To his embarrassment, however, the gangster himself appeared on news channels to deny the CM's assertion.

To try and stamp down on gangland violence, Mann had constituted an anti-gangster task force under intelligence hawk Pramod Ban, which has so far neutralised five gangsters and arrested 564. On February 26, two gangsters lodged in Goindwal jail—Mandeep Toofan and Mohan Singh—were killed, and a third, Keshaw, was critically injured after a rival gang attacked them. The two accused were in jail for Moosewala's murder. But the bulk of the high-profile cases, be it Moosewala's killing, nabbing Pradeep Singh's shooters or cracking down on other gangsters, have been handled either by the central agencies or by the Delhi Police. The National Investigation Agency (NIA) has since September last year taken on the investigations into the nexus of gangs active in Punjab with the militants.

Arresting individual gangsters reduces their impact, but more are on their way, says a top police officer in Punjab. He believes his side is fighting a losing battle as they find it difficult to break the entire gang network because key links and leaders are hiding in countries like Canada, Thailand, Malaysia, Hong Kong and Australia; and many of the gangsters continue to operate from jail. According to cops, at least 73 gangs are active in Punjab. Acting DGP Yadav believes that many of the gangsters also continue to take instructions from erstwhile militants. The NIA has good reason to trace a trail between several gangsters and dreaded militants like Lakhbir Singh Rode, Paramjit Panjwar, Harvinder Singh Rinda etc. living across the border in Pakistan. In short, it's the sort of combustible situation that cries out for a strong, experienced hand at the wheel.

HIS MASTER'S VOICE?

Experts say the real concern is that, unlike his predecessors Badal and Amarinder, Mann has no history in panthic politics and is thus clueless about its inner dynamics. Coming from a Communist background, he rose to prominence with his satires on politicians, bureaucracy, the police and the challenges faced by the state. But now he often finds the joke to be on him. Last September, Mann's trip to Germany became a diplomatic nightmare after he claimed that post his visit to luxury automobile manufacturer BMW's facility, the German motor company has decided to set up a unit in Punjab. BMW denied it the same evening. Gaffes like these only serve to expose his lack of experience.

Mann's actions also give the impression of his being remote-controlled by the AAP top brass in Delhi. The party is accused of running Punjab like the East India Company ran its Indian possessions, especially with the Mann government allegedly using funds and resources from the state to promote the party's electoral needs in Gujarat, Goa and Himachal Pradesh, where assembly elections were held last year. For instance, in February, Mann offered to buy onions from Gujarat farmers. This angered Punjab cultivators, who complain that the government has yet to buy the pulses they had grown despite the CM's assurance.

Last April, in the national capital, Mann signed a knowledge-sharing agreement with the Kejriwal-led Delhi govern-